



Psiphon

Interesting name. What is Psiphon?

It's a system that allows people in countries where the Internet is censored (like China and Iran) to view any Web page they'd like to. Say you're in China, and the government has blocked access to Wikipedia. You have the address of a Psiphon node (a Psiphonode)—a computer running the Psiphon software in a free country—and an account there. You log on to that node, then type in the Web page address. The request is routed through the Psiphonode and your browser displays the page.

So who sets up Psiphonodes?

People and institutions willing to help. Anyone can install the Psiphon software on his computer, and it becomes a Web proxy for Psiphonites (those whose access is censored) to connect to.

Where do Psiphonites get the address of a Psiphonode?

People post requests for server addresses on forums, or call friends and family. If you run a Psiphonode and see a request from someone, you might send him your server address, and create an account for him.

Why can't censoring governments block Psiphon?

The Psiphonite connects to Psiphonodes whose addresses only a few people know. (To block access to a site, you need the IP...) Still, the forums where Psiphonites make requests for Psiphonode addresses have been known to be blocked.

When did the system go live?

In December of 2006. Forums are active, though we don't know how many people are using the system.

How does the whole thing remain legal?

It doesn't. In some countries, bypassing censorship is illegal. But a Higher Law would say censorship is illegal, that's why people are trying to help out.

notes that the "Google generation" prefers visual over textual information, but that text is still important—and visual media can lose its appeal very quickly. The study also notes that this generation has scant regard for copyright laws, and that plagiarism is rampant.

Interestingly, this generation is multitasking almost all the time, and the demand for instant gratification is constant; however, there is no hard evidence that young people are more impatient.

In spite of the results, the study warns libraries from trying to be more tech-savvy by, say, opening communities on Orkut, suggesting that this may result in the younger generation seeing it as "invading their space."

MORE OLPC WOES

Two's A Crowd, Says Microsoft

Just when news about the OLPC Project started slacking, there came another bit to trouble the

organisation. Nicholas Negroponte recently reported that the OLPC Foundation was working in collaboration with Microsoft to create a dual-boot version of its laptops meant for children, the XO. This was, however, quickly squashed by a statement made by a Microsoft representative, who went on to say, "While we have investigated the possibility in the past, Microsoft is not developing dual-boot Windows XP support for One Laptop Per Child's XO laptop."

Though this might seem a flat-out denial from Microsoft, there seems to be some confusion in the statement here. It is true that Microsoft is working with the OLPC Foundation to bring Windows XP to the XO. This will, however, be done in a different manner. Microsoft's plan is to load the OS onto a 2 GB SD Flash memory card, which can then be used to run on the XO. This is because the Windows environment requires at least 1 GB of space to run even a stripped-down version of Windows XP, along with any other program on the XO. To

revert to the XO's Sugar interface—its OS—one needs to shut down the XO, remove the SD Flash card, and reboot.

Since this is different from a traditional dual-boot system, this is where—we believe—

Negroponte was confused. Taking a pot-shot at the OLPC chairman, Microsoft also suggested that they be contacted for

further updates on the Windows-run XO, rather than any other source.

ONLINE COMMUNITIES SCARY!

What Parents Think

A recent survey by the Center for the Digital Future at the USC Annenberg School for Communication—for parents with children who regularly logged on to the Internet—found that two-thirds of parents are uncomfortable with their children participating in online communities, and half of them think online predators are a threat. However, 80 per cent agreed that the Internet is a valuable source of information, and ranked it higher than newspapers, television, radio, and even books.

The survey has been on for the last seven years, and trends have emerged. Logging on to the Internet is no more considered by parents as a distraction—naturally. Thirteen per cent of the parents felt their wards spent too much time online—a figure that has increased since last year, an not surprisingly. Another trend that has emerged is that more and more parents are finding it worrying that their kids are involved in online communities, but they don't deem chatting and e-mailing as harmful or potentially dangerous.

Obviously, the next generation's voice is the exact opposite—most kids polled report being avid users of community Web sites, with 71 per cent claiming that their social membership was "extremely important," and 54 per cent logging in to their online communities every day. ■

